

Ophelia

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Figure 1: A 360° immersive experience in a milestone in the history of art: the story behind the iconic painting “Ophelia” by the Pre-Raphaelite painter John Everett Millais.

ACM Reference Format:

Diana Dell’Erba. 2024. Ophelia. In *SIGGRAPH Asia 2024 XR (SA XR ’24)*, December 03–06, 2024, Tokyo, Japan. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 1 page. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3681759.3688907>

1 Introduction

“OPHELIA” takes place in the Victorian era and focuses on one of the most well-known, fascinating and dramatic anecdotes in Western art, which occurred during the creation of the famous Pre-Raphaelite painting ‘Ophelia’ by John Everett Millais. It takes place entirely inside Millais’ London apartment, accompanying the viewer in the last moments of painting’s creation. To faithfully reproduce the girl’s drowning, Millais has his muse immersed in a bathtub heated only by faint candles that slowly go out. Lizzie Siddal, her future husband, the poet and painter Dante Gabriel Rossetti, and the author of the painting, each of them carries on a personal struggle:

Lizzie in resisting in a tub of by now frozen water, Millais against his disappointment at not being able to portray the passage between life and death in its essence and Rossetti in trying to convince his beloved to resist. In the name of Art, the muse stoically continues to pose, contracting a ferocious bronchitis which will then definitively undermine her health. In this room-drama, tensions, melancholy and passion form the backdrop until they unite the protagonists, between torment and comfort, in a loving embrace.

“OPHELIA” wants to focus on the theme of sacrifice, that thin thread that often runs in the life of an artist between taking care of one’s person and giving oneself to Art. Represented by this real event, albeit of great symbolic strength, the short-film questions tension towards perfection of the artist to whom the work never ceases to appear incomplete and imperfect.

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SA XR ’24, December 03–06, 2024, Tokyo, Japan

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ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-1141-1/24/12

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3681759.3688907>